

The Long Tail Never Serves

Auditing a Dining Hall's Forty-Dish Rotation Roster Against a Term of Till Tallies

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Background

The rotation roster promises forty dishes spread evenly across the term, guarding against diner fatigue. Whether the till rings up that spread — or leans on a handful of favourites — has never been checked against the roster it is meant to fulfil.

Aims

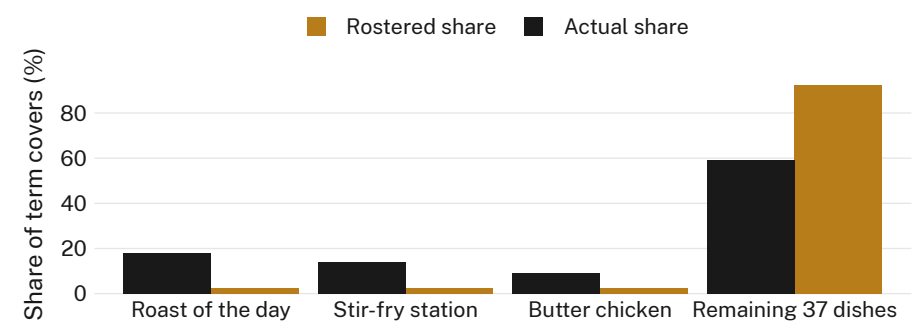
- Match till dish-codes against the forty-dish rotation, week by week
- Establish how evenly serving volume spreads across rostered dishes
- Test whether concentration deepens across the term's second half

Methods

- n = 14 weeks · dining hall till exports · daily dish-code tallies, one Autumn term
- rostered target of 2.5% of covers per dish held as comparison baseline
- dish-code mapping cross-checked weekly against the published roster; no amendments logged

Results

Three of the roster's forty dishes draw 41% of covers against a combined rostered share of 7.5%; the remaining thirty-seven, rostered for 92.5% combined, return 59%, and eleven are never rung once.



Three of the roster's forty dishes draw 41% of covers across the fourteen-week Autumn term against a combined 7.5% rostered share; eleven of the remaining thirty-seven are never rung once.

Discussion & conclusions

The roster's even-spread target does not survive the till. A small head of dishes absorbs the demand the rotation was built to distribute, and a third of its tail is never called at all; the roster itself carries no mechanism for retiring a dish that never sells. Next: testing whether re-weighting the roster toward demonstrated demand moves anything the till records, or simply grows a new head.

References

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Till exports de-identified at source; no diner-level purchase data retained. Rotation roster supplied by catering administration under an internal data-sharing agreement.

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